

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 21-23

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 21

The Panther and the Fire

“DO YOU STILL HAVE your cutting stone?” I asked Joseph, as we hid behind the tree.

“Yes, always. I’ll cut her down. I can slip up behind her, but once she’s on her feet, the guards will come after us. And they don’t have to outrun us. They have shotguns.”

“I can lead her to her family,” I said.

“We need some way to distract the soldiers,” Joseph said, “some way to slow them down.”

“I think a strong panther could handle the soldiers,” I said. “You’ve done it before.”

“What can I do?” Nita asked.

“You can wake up the Choctaw Council, the men and women, all of them. Let them know what happened. When the soldiers chase us, they can delay them. Every minute is important,” I said.

“I understand,” Nita said. She disappeared into the night fog, a five-year-old Choctaw girl — a ghost — making her first appearance before the Choctaw Council. Her sister’s life was at stake.

Joseph and I circled the camp. Pointy Nose and Roundman sat on a log by the fire, their shotguns close-by. We crept behind the tree and waited. The quarter moon cast a bright light through the naked branches of the tree.

Joseph pointed to the sky. A huge cloud moved across the sky. I understood. We would wait till the cloud covered the moon.

“You take first watch,” said Pointy Nose. “I’m going to sleep.”

“That’s not a good idea,” Roundman said. “You saw how mad he was. If something happens, we’ll be hanging from that tree. And not by our wrists.”

“He wouldn’t hang us!” Pointy Nose said.

“Want to risk your life?” asked Roundman. “Not me. You stay here and I’ll watch the girl.” He rose and moved by the tree where Naomi hung. Roundman leaned against the trunk, three feet from us!

We sat so quiet, in fear for our lives. If Roundman stepped around the tree, all three of us would be dead. He held his shotgun ready to fire.

What happened next could never be planned.

Something licked me on the ankle. I looked at my feet. There stood Jumper, wagging his tail and ready to play! I froze.

Please don't let him bark, I thought. I wanted to ask him how he had found me, but there was no time. We needed a distraction, and Jumper was ready to play.

As quietly as I could, I ran to the river and Jumper dashed after me. At just the right moment, the cloud covered the moon and the sky turned dark. With a loud splash, Jumper dove in the river!

"What was that?" Roundman shouted.

"Something fell in the river," Pointy Nose said, and the two soldiers followed the noise.

Boom! Roundman's shotgun blasted and soon the camp was scrambling with soldiers.

"What's going on!" shouted Leader, as he hurried to the riverbank.

"Someone stay with the girl," said Leader, and a soldier stayed behind. He touched Naomi's feet with the barrel of his shotgun. Naomi jerked.

“Don’t you worry,” he said, with a cruel smile in his voice. “You’re not going anywhere.”

I hid behind the hanging tree. No one could see me, I was sure of that. Joseph was gone. I heard a clawing sound and looked above me. The panther crouched on the tree limb, gnawing on the rope.

Suddenly, Naomi fell to the ground. The panther leapt on the soldier and his shotgun went flying.

“We have to run,” I said. “Can you make it?”

“Lead the way,” she said. She was shaking, but I knew she was strong. Her wrists were still tied to the rope, but we had no time to stop. She dragged

the rope behind her as she ran. The panther ran to the fire and slapped the burning logs, sending fiery embers all about the camp.

Boom! Boom! Boom! The soldiers fired at Jumper in the river.

“Let him be,” shouted Leader. “It’s only a dog.”

“Look!” said Roundman. “The camp is on fire!”

The soldiers returned to camp, ready for battle. Panther Joseph was ready, too. He gripped a burning log in his teeth and jumped into a wagon. The cloth top of the wagon burst into flames.

The panther wasn’t finished. He roared his panther cry and jumped under the burning wagon, hiding himself in the flames. When the wagon collapsed, he leapt to a tree, climbed up the trunk, and disappeared in the branches.

Two soldiers surrounded the tree and fired their shotguns overhead. A blast hit the limb where the panther crouched. Before it hit the ground, the panther jumped on the soldiers, knocking both of them off their feet.

With all eyes on the panther, Naomi and I were far from the camp before they realized she was gone. When we arrived at the Choctaw Council wagon everyone was wide-awake. They were expecting us.

Nita did her job, I thought.

“You are the captured girl?” a councilwoman asked.

“Yes,” said Naomi.

“Here,” she said, “let me help you.” She hurried to the wagon and returned with a sharp knife. She sliced the rope and tossed it in the campfire.

“We don’t want the soldiers to see that,” she said. “Now, you must leave. The soldiers will be here soon. Can you find your way to your family by yourself?”

“I am not by myself,” Naomi said. I realized the woman couldn’t see me. I floated into sight.

“Oh,” the councilwoman said, “I see you are protected by our ghost friend. But you must hurry. We’ll do what we can to stop them.”

We ran without looking behind. I soon realized Naomi was faster than me. This was only my first day, I hadn’t learned to run like a ghost!

The panther was faster than us both. The soldiers fired their guns at us, but we had a big lead. They returned to their camp and the burning wagon, while we hurried down the line of walkers, nearing my family’s camp.

Luke saw us first. "You must be Naomi," he said. "We don't have time to talk, not now. You know you can't stay here. Your mother and father are with my family. This is the first place they will look."

My parents stood with Gabe and Ruth.

"Where can I go?" Naomi asked.

"We have a wagon ready," said Luke. "Follow me."

"Wait," Naomi said.

"There is no time," said Luke. "We have to go!"

"There is time for this," Naomi said. She stretched out her arms and her mother and father ran to greet her.

"We were so afraid for you," Ruth said.

"You know that Nita is gone?" asked Gabe.

“Hey!” Nita’s sweet voice always came when least expected.

She floated into sight. “I’m not gone. I’m just a ghost, but I am still part of the family.”

Only Nita could bring smiles on a day like today.

“Of course,” said Ruth, “family stays together. Always.”

“You better be going,” Gabe said.

“*Chi pisa lachike*,” they whispered. Both of my families waved when we left the camp.

“*Chi pisa lachike*,” they said.

We followed Luke to a Choctaw wagon a half-mile down the road.

“They are waiting for you,” he said. “We didn’t know you would come so soon. But after Nita spoke to us, we told them everything. They are ready to hide you, Naomi.”

Luke led us to the rear of the covered wagon.

Who would risk their lives by hiding Naomi? I asked myself.

I soon had my answer.

“We are here!” Luke called to the people in the wagon. An old woman with wrinkled skin and long white hair stuck her head through the curtain. She nodded and flung the curtain open. Three even older women smiled and welcomed Naomi into their wagon, into their world.

The world of the bonepickers.

I lifted my arms and passed through the wagon walls.



Chapter 22

Buried with the Bones

“WE HAVE BEEN waiting for you,” said the woman. “Take your shoes off before you climb in the wagon. We keep everything neat and clean.”

Naomi leaned against a wheel and slipped off her boots.

“Here,” said the woman, “hand them to me. I’ll hide them for you.” She helped Naomi into the wagon and closed the flap. Once inside, Naomi was struck by the smell of dried rose petals.

“Mmmm,” she said, “it smells nice in here.” The women were silent, but Naomi thought she heard soft laughter.

“We are so used to the smells, we barely notice,” said the woman. “But we try to keep everything nice for the others.”

“What others?” asked Naomi.

More soft laughter floated from the rear of the wagon.

“Everybody else,” said the woman. “Most people don’t like to be around us.”

“Why not?” The words had barely passed through Naomi’s lips when she wished she had never uttered them. In a sudden flash, like a thunderbolt that shook her very being, Naomi realized where she was.

“I’m in the wagon of the bonepickers,” she whispered.

Few Choctaws have ever seen the bonepickers, but everyone knew of them. Before the soldiers came, they lived in a thicket of trees, deep in the piney woods. They never left their tiny log house.

A small pond lay close to their back door, gushing warm water from far underground. A young man brought them food and supplies, so they never had to leave home. Their job was the hardest and most sacred in all of Choctaw country.

When a Choctaw died, the body was brought to the bonepickers. They carried the body to a wooden platform close to the spring, where animals came to drink. After days, sometimes weeks, when the wolves and buzzards had eaten the flesh from the bones, the bonepickers began their real task.

They carried the body inside and picked the bones clean. They washed and scrubbed the bones till they were shiny and white. With a thin rope made from the clothing, they tied the bones into a bundle. This bundle was now ready for burial.

This was the Choctaw way.

And now, with Choctaws forced to walk, the bonepickers had to leave their home, too. They were too old to walk. Urged by the Choctaw Council, the soldiers gave them a wagon. This was the wagon Naomi had climbed into, a wagon sweetened by the smell of dried roses.

“Don’t worry, dear child,” the woman said. “Don’t be afraid of us. This is the safest place for you now. If the soldiers search the wagon, we have a place for you.”

Naomi’s eyes adjusted to the darkness. She saw the three older women, curled together at the rear of the wagon. They surrounded a large wooden trunk.

“Here,” said the woman, lifting the lid. “You will be safe in the trunk.”

Naomi took a deep breath and froze. The trunk was filled with bones!

“Don’t be afraid,” the woman said. “You do not have to touch the bones. The men built a secret hiding place for you.”

The woman piled the bones into two large sacks. While Naomi watched, they lifted the floor of the trunk.

“It has a secret bottom, a tiny place for you to lie and wait till the soldiers go away. Here, climb inside.”

Naomi crawled into the trunk, lay on her back, and closed her eyes.

“Take this,” said the woman, handing Naomi a blanket. “This will keep you warm.”

The women settled the wooden plank on top of her, and emptied the bags of bones into the trunk.

Naomi heard the bones scatter and roll, only a few inches above her head. The air was stuffy, but she could breathe. She curled under the blanket and waited.

I hope I don't have to stay here long, she thought.

“I know what you're thinking,” the woman said, and the bonepickers laughed. “We'll do our best to see that your stay is short.”

“Oh, don’t say that,” said an older woman, in a cracked and tiny voice. “She seems so nice. Maybe she can stay and help us.”

Naomi felt the wagon move. The bones creaked and rattled above her. She listened while the woman spoke to Luke.

“Have your panther friend bring us a small animal from the woods, a possum or raccoon,” she said.

“I’ll tell him right away,” said Luke.

“Tell him to gnaw the animal, make it good and bloody!” the woman shouted. “The more blood the better!”



Chapter 23

Naomi and the Bonepickers

I KNEW NAOMI needed me, now more than ever. I slipped through the walls of the trunk. I was learning when to disappear and when to be seen. I let my body give off a soft glow, slowly coming to life before her eyes.

“Do everything they say and you will be safe,” I whispered. “Joseph will be nearby, to warn us when the soldiers come. They’ll never find you here.”

“Why do they want a bloody animal?” Naomi asked.

“I don’t know. We’ll have to wait and see.”

We didn’t have long to wait. After only a few minutes, Panther Joseph caught a fat raccoon. He dragged the dead raccoon across the ground,

then crouched and leapt into the wagon, dropping the raccoon before the bonepickers.

I lifted my arms and floated through the top of the trunk. I wanted to see what the woman would do with a bloody dead raccoon. Panther Joseph had done what she asked. The raccoon was slashed and cut from head to tail.

Panther teeth cuts , I thought.

A thick trail of blood stretched across the floor of the wagon. The woman took the raccoon by the neck and flung it in a circle over her head. Blood flew everywhere, on the walls, the trunk, and all over the woman. She lifted the lid of the trunk and held the raccoon over the pile of bones.

As I watched, the woman squeezed the raccoon tight and wrung it out, like she was squeezing water from a wet towel.

Blood dripped on the bones.

“Oh!” Naomi shouted.

I returned to the trunk and hovered over Naomi.

"I'm here, Naomi," I said.

"Help me," Naomi whispered.

Blood dripped through the cracks in the floor and fell like raindrops on Naomi's face.

"Nooo," she cried.

"Shhhhh," said the woman. "We have to do this. Once the soldiers look in the trunk, they'll leave us alone."

"She's right, Naomi," I whispered. "Nothing scares *Nahullos* like bloody bones."

"I think I'd rather be a ghost," said Naomi.

"Don't think like that. What about your mother and father? One ghost daughter is enough."

"You're right," she said. "*Hoke*, just get me out of here as soon as you can."

"I'll do my best, but I have to leave you now."

Luke and Joseph waited for me by the river. The snow fell thick and they were shivering cold. Bits of blood and raccoon fur dotted Joseph's face and hair.

"You should wash up before anybody sees you," I told him.

“Oh, sorry,” said Joseph. He grabbed a handful of snow and washed himself clean.

“How long will Naomi stay with the bonepickers?” he asked.

“Till it’s safe,” Luke answered. “Remember they are looking for a girl with short hair, cut like a boy’s. The women have a plan to hide Naomi in plain sight. They are weaving a long hairpiece for her to wear.”

“It might work,” said Joseph. “For now, Isaac and I will wait here. We’ll let you know when anything happens,” Joseph said.

“I’ll do the same,” Luke promised. “I need to get back to the family. *Chi pisa lachike.*”

“Don’t go yet,” a deep voice said.

Luke stopped in his tracks. He stood speechless, his eyes filled with wonder. A thick white cloud covered us, and when it lifted, Old Man stood among us.

I am the only ghost Luke has ever seen, I thought. He's entering my world now, the living place of ghosts.

"We want to tell you three young men how proud we are of what you have done today," Old Man said.

He nodded and lifted his arms. In the dark of the woods the air trembled with light. One by one they appeared, until at least a hundred Choctaw ghosts encircled us.

They were the walking ones who never left us. In times of trouble they are there. We know this, but sometimes we must be reminded.

Our deeds touch not only the living. We did more than save Naomi today. We made our people proud. That is the highest honor a Choctaw can ever earn, to make the ancestors proud.

They spoke in a single voice and with a single word they honored us.

"Yakoke," they said. "Thank you."

As suddenly as they appeared, the ghosts were gone. Luke said not a word.

He looked at Joseph and me, then turned quickly and started home. When he thought we weren't looking, he broke into a run.

"He'll get used to it," said Joseph.

"He'd better," I said, "now that his little brother is a ghost."

Sometime after midnight the wind grew angry and sleet replaced the friendly snow. Watching the ice fall, I was glad to be a ghost. I couldn't feel

a thing. Joseph wrapped himself tight in my blanket, but I knew he was freezing. We couldn't risk a fire.

"The snow has covered our footprints," I said, "and the ice will slow them down in the morning."

"Yes, I'm glad for that," Joseph said, through chattering teeth. "Let's hope for more ice!"

As if in reply, a branch heavy with ice cracked and landed at our feet.

"Careful what you wish for," I reminded him.